early twenties and went to the US on H-1B and H-4 visas. From 2001–08, he worked in the residential construction segment in Washington DC and suffered his share of ups and downs in the job market. His only sibling, a sister, lives on the US East Coast. After his father's death in 2008, Krishna returned to Hospet/Anegundi. His household now includes his mother, wife, son (eighteen) and twin daughters (twelve). But none live at this ancestral home: the daughters attend school in Hospet and the son attends high school in Bengaluru.

Growing up, Krishna says, he cared little about Indian history or his royal ancestry. While he himself married a 'commoner', a nonroyal woman he knew since childhood, until the previous generation his family tended to marry only within other royal families. His mother is from the royal family of Narsinghgarh, a former princely state in Madhya Pradesh, and which claims descent from Raja Bhoj. It was only in the US that his family history and Vijayanagar's past began to interest him. As he discovered his roots, he began to imagine a new sense of purpose and life path for himself.

Krishna gives me a tour of his beautiful double-storeyed home. He renovated it for years after his return. It combines a traditional layout and architectural flourishes with Western-style bathrooms, skylights, a modern kitchen and a home theatre. Ornate teak wood pillars, beams and carved doors coexist with high-tech, smartphone-controlled lights. Vaastu-inspired architectural designs go hand in hand with solar panels, an inverter battery unit and a reverse osmosis water system for the whole house. His home library brims with American sci-fi and fantasy fiction that his kids read. Krishna now mostly reads books on spirituality and the history of Vijayanagar.

Krishna inherited forty acres of agricultural land on which he is trying out a new mix of crops beyond paddy, bananas and sugarcane, such as coconuts and mangoes. He keeps two desi cows to ensure pure milk. He is also reviving a dormant family business of mining iron ore. A good chunk of central Anegundi belongs to the family, including the ruined palace. The family must decide what to do with the fort and palace—turn it into a heritage hotel? A museum? An information centre on Hampi? In a partially restored corner of the palace lives his uncle, Rama Devaraya, seventy-five, a garrulous man with a sharp memory, who spends a lot of time in his veranda overlooking the ruins. When I briefly meet him later, he explains